missiles in Cuba. After these promises—both public and private—Khrushchev proceeded to do what he had forsworn. If Khrushchev could so miscalculate the President's meaning and mettle, what line could the President draw that Khrushchev would respect? Third, the Soviet emplacement of missiles in Cuba seemed tied to the Soviet plan for action on Berlin. If the United States simply accepted Soviet action in Cuba, it might not be able to persuade the Soviet Union that it was willing to run the risk of nuclear war to preserve Berlin. Finally, the fact that the Soviet leaders had taken such a reckless step suggested that they did not appreciate how dangerous and precarious were relations between nuclear superpowers. Until this was rooted in their minds, they might continue to take actions that ran significant risks of nuclear war, hoping that the United States would yield rather than accept such risks. Though dangerous, Cuba was nonetheless likely to be more manageable than Berlin, or the crisis after Berlin. Nowhere outside the continental United States did we enjoy such a comparative advantage in conventional forces.

Thus President Kennedy might have justified his action as the lesser of risky alternatives. To the question that had begun to trouble Robert Kennedy—What right or justification is there for bringing people under such risk?—he might have answered: I did not bring people under such risk; this is simply our present condition. But Robert Kennedy's question seems to ask: what justification can there be for tolerating that condition? What seems immoral and, indeed, irrational and intolerable is that technology forces fallible human beings to make choices about life and death for hundreds of millions of other human beings. Would any reasonable man choose to live in such a world? The nuclear paradox cannot be denied. But can it be accepted?

One way to avoid the bite of Robert Kennedy's question lies in wishing risks away, discounting by denying them, or closing eyes to them. The authors of this Afterword have heard a lot of wishing done by government officials in the aftermath of Cuba. Some men near the Ex Comm but not of it—mainly military officers advising in subordinate capacities—have argued strongly that from the moment President Kennedy went on the air to publicize American awareness and reaction there was never a substantial risk of nuclear war. Faced by our obvious superiority, both strategic and tactical, the Russians, being rational, were bound to retreat. What then of Kennedy's perception, movingly attested by his brother, that the risk of holocaust was real? These officers dismiss it as "flap in the White House." Other men, including some who sat